FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

India is littered with archaeological treasures. The most well-known, of course, is the Taj Mahal, whose risks of deterioration are almost as famous as the monument itself. Ajanta was declared a Unesco World Heritage Site alongside the Taj in 1983 but has yet to get similar attention. It is over a millennium older, although history-writers are still debating other primary facts about it. The consensus is, it was built in two phases, separated by seven centuries. Around the late 2nd century BC, sometime after Emperor Ashoka had spread Buddhism around India, monks cut the first six caves into those cliffs above the Waghora River. The early murals did not depict the Buddha directly. Then, circa 460 AD, Ajanta came back to life with a full renaissance-like bloom under Vakataka king Harisena. And was mysteriously abandoned around 480 AD. Left behind was a spectacular art gallery set into 30-odd caves: the Buddha in human form, in sculpture and mural, a teeming pantheon, and Jataka narratives in brilliant colours.

You may wonder why a newsmagazine should do a cover story on Ajanta amid a bustling news menu. Well, sometimes an unusual story comes knocking at your door. Not immediate news but of national importance. My friend and former colleague, the eminent photographer Raghu Rai, called me in a state of distress. He told me how badly the murals had deteriorated since his last visit four decades ago. He red-flagged grievous flaws—from hopeless overtourism to "disco lighting". The pique was understandable: he was refused permission to use his flash according to the rules, while tour guides wantonly flashed their torches. And tungsten and mercury lighting produced horrid greens and browns on film. The crowds too had grown exponentially. Ajanta receives 400,000 visitors annually, and about a hundred people throng each cave in peak season, raising humidity and carbon dioxide levels and exacerbating an already harmful microclimate. We decided to focus national attention on this precious heritage and explore how to stem its decay.



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One thousand years of abandonment had wrought havoc, with seepage, dust and everything from bacteria to bats corroding a quarter of the murals. Ajanta was mentioned by the 7th century Chinese monk Hiuen Tsang and in the *Ain-i-Akbari*. But the world truly awakened to it only after a British tiger-hunting party in 1819, under Captain John Smith, stumbled upon its ruins in the jungle. Its estimation has only grown since. Historian Walter Smith called it "the apogee of India's Golden Age". Artist Amrita Sher-Gil said even "one fresco at Ajanta... was worth more than the whole Renaissance". Mural conservator Sanjay Dhar told us it's "the mother lode of Asian art"—with the Chinese and Japanese "all in debt to that one place".

But those murals are in peril. Varnish and shellac, applied during the colonial age, cracked, flaked off and changed the colours. What we have is a peeling, fading patchwork. Saving that is a sacred duty, both for its own sake and because it's the black box that holds the key to so much about India's history, art and religion. This is where modern policy is caught in a dilemma. How to preserve the site but allow people to enjoy its wonders.

Countries adopt different, often extreme, techniques to preserve fragile heritage. France's Lascaux is closed for visitors, its Spanish cousin Altamira lets in only a handful when it does, crowds are regulated with Chinese efficiency at the Caves of the Thousand Buddhas in Mogao, Japan's Horyuji murals mostly spend time in a vault after a disastrous fire in the 1940s, and only 30 advance-bookers at a time can see Da Vinci's 'The Last Supper' in the refectory of Milan's Santa Maria delle Grazie church.

The West cares for its heritage but that doesn't guarantee excellent results. Lascaux's Palaeolithic art is in a royal mess because of human intervention: its recent conservation history reads like an epic battle between 21st century scientists and millennia-old microorganisms, and the latter are winning. Van Gogh's vibrant colours have been changing hue—purple is turning into blue as its red constituent gradually vanishes, and some yellows are browning. The culprit is light—both natural and artificial museum lighting—and how sensitive those first-generation chemical pigments are to it.

India has a schizoid approach to heritage: we are good at making a big noise about it, but don't much care for it beyond the symbolic power it grants us as a "civilisation". We tend to prettify things only when the world is watching. For example, a G20 event was to be held in Ajanta, but the road leading to it could not be completed in time. Why it was not there in the first place is an open question.

Managing Editor Sunil Menon spent over a month researching the subject on either side of a field visit. He pored over the historical scholarship and dozens of journal articles, besides speaking to an array of institutional and independent experts, scientists and conservators. The verdict: the crisis is real. What we have is a permanent state of heritage emergency. The ASI has dedicated footsoldiers, but India's official conservation culture has a familiar sarkari air of things running on slow-motion autopilot. The ASI and the Maharashtra Tourism Development Corporation (MTDC)—the other management entity at Ajanta—don't converse with each other. And the ASI's proprietorial air ensures India's best mural specialists don't get to work on Ajanta when it's clearly an all-hands-on-the-deck situation and heritage is more precious than institutional ego. The overall policy is criminally stagnant at several levels. MTDC's state-of-the-art Visitor Centre, for instance. Built on a soft loan of Rs 125 crore from the Japanese, it was opened with much hoopla in 2013 but has been lying shuttered since 2017! Brooms went into action only when the G20 delegation threatened to visit. Raghu Rai's concerns about lighting are not entirely off either, even if four important caves have been lit by heat-less fibre-optics since 2002 and the others are changing to LED. The latter, for instance, is cited as among Van Gogh's villains.

This tale of the human battle against decay is epic and shambolic. Raghu Rai recreates for us through colour correction what the murals might have looked like in their full glory. We also propose a template for a solution that entails reimagining Ajanta as the hub of a heritage sector, a conservation approach alive to the rapidly advancing science, and a monitoring body comprising the best from India and abroad. Conservator Dhar, who trained under the Italian master who restored the Sistine Chapel, told us he found his calling in life after an INDIA TODAY feature on Ajanta in the 1980s. We give you this issue to spark interest in future generations for India's history, archaeology and conservation of its precious heritage. Because we have the past strewn all around us, we must stop behaving like profligate heritage billionaires.

(Aroon Purie)